News Use and Civic Engagement

A styled Quarto manuscript for communication and journalism students

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This example manuscript models the structure of a short social science paper in communication and journalism. It uses a small fictional survey to examine whether different patterns of news use are associated with civic engagement. The document demonstrates common manuscript elements: theory, research questions, hypotheses, methods, a table, a figure, an equation, citations, and reproducible code syntax.

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Research summary. This teaching example uses a fictional survey to model a compact empirical paper: a communication theory claim, a testable expectation, a transparent measure, a labeled table, a cross-referenced figure, and a numbered Nature-style reference list.

1 Introduction

Journalism scholars often ask how news exposure shapes what people know, what issues they consider important, and whether they participate in civic life. Classic agenda-setting research argues that news coverage can influence which public issues become salient to audiences[1]. Framing research adds that news stories also shape interpretation by emphasizing some aspects of an issue over others[2].

This teaching manuscript uses a fictional survey to ask a simple question: are students who report higher news use also more civically engaged? The example is intentionally small so that students can focus on the logic of a social science manuscript and the Quarto features used to write one.

2 Theory and Expectations

News use may support civic engagement by increasing issue awareness, providing practical information about public affairs, and making political participation feel more relevant. Prior research on media effects also shows that the relationship between news and participation depends on message content, audience motivation, and social context[3,4].

This example paper uses one research question and one hypothesis:

RQ1: How does average civic engagement vary across news-use groups?

H1: Students in higher news-use groups will report higher civic-engagement scores than students in lower news-use groups.

3 Methods

The fictional dataset contains 12 observations. Each row represents one survey respondent. News use is grouped into four categories, and civic engagement is measured on a 1 to 5 scale, where higher values indicate greater self-reported engagement.

Table 1: Fictional survey data for a communication research example.

ID	News-use group	Civic-engagement score
1	Low	2.1
2	Low	2.5
3	Low	2.6
4	Mixed	2.8
5	Mixed	3.0
6	Mixed	3.2
7	High local	3.4
8	High local	3.6
9	High local	3.8
10	High national	4.1
11	High national	4.2
12	High national	4.6

The mean civic-engagement score for each group is calculated using Equation 1.

$$\bar{y}_g = \frac{1}{n_g} \sum_{i=1}^{n_g} y_{ig} \tag{1}$$

In Equation 1, $\bar{y}_g$ is the mean engagement score for group g, n_g is the number of respondents in that group, and y_{ig} is respondent i's engagement score.

4 Results

Figure 1 summarizes the group means from Table 1.

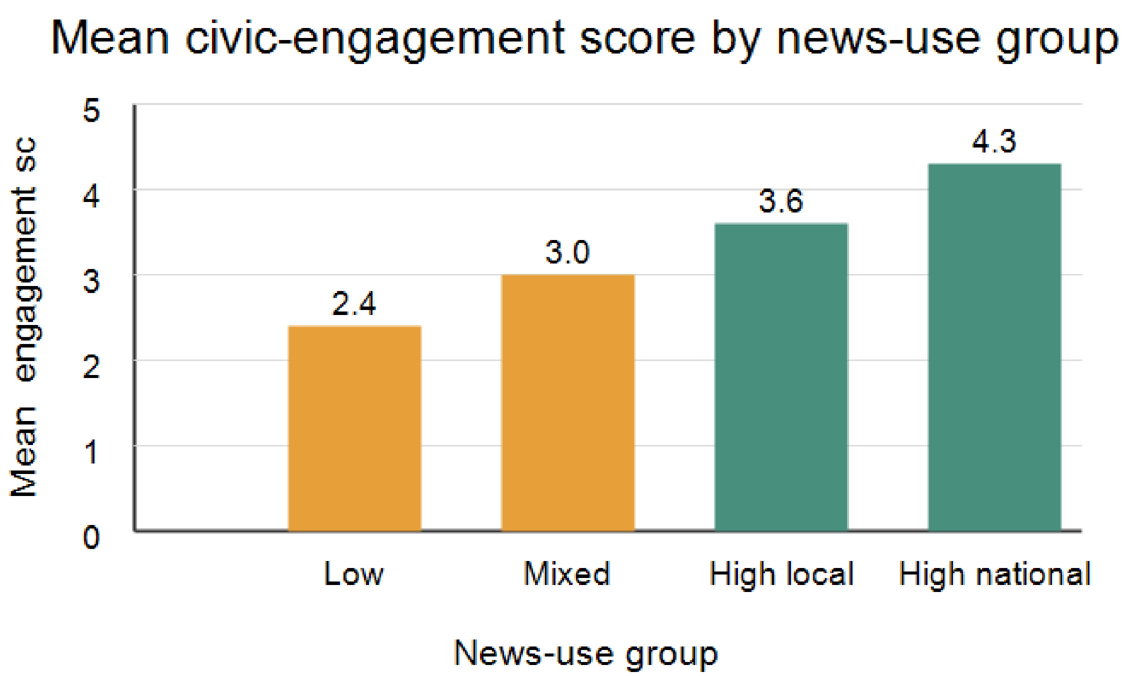

Figure 1: Mean civic-engagement score by news-use group.

Table 2: Group means shown in Figure 1.

News-use group	Mean civic-engagement score	Interpretation
Low	2.4	Lowest engagement in the example data
Mixed	3.0	Moderate engagement
High local	3.6	Higher engagement
High national	4.3	Highest engagement in the example data

The following Python chunk shows how the group means could be generated from the same values listed in Table 1. Execution is disabled in the YAML header so the manuscript renders without requiring Python or Jupyter. To run the code during rendering, set `execute.enabled` and `execute.eval` to `true`.

```python
survey = [
    ("Low", 2.1), ("Low", 2.5), ("Low", 2.6),
    ("Mixed", 2.8), ("Mixed", 3.0), ("Mixed", 3.2),
    ("High local", 3.4), ("High local", 3.6), ("High local", 3.8),
    ("High national", 4.1), ("High national", 4.2), ("High national", 4.6),
]

groups = {}
for news_group, score in survey:
    groups.setdefault(news_group, []).append(score)

for news_group, scores in groups.items():
    mean_score = sum(scores) / len(scores)
    print(f"{news_group}: {mean_score:.1f}")
```

The pattern in Table 2 is consistent with H1. The low news-use group has the lowest mean engagement score, while the high national news-use group has the highest mean score. Because this is a fictional teaching dataset, the result should be read as an example of manuscript structure rather than as evidence about actual student behavior.

5 Discussion

This example follows a common social science paper structure:

- The introduction motivates a communication problem.
- The theory section connects the question to prior literature.
- The methods section defines the sample, variables, and calculation.
- The results section reports a table, a figure, and an interpretable pattern.
- The discussion explains the meaning and limits of the result.

For journalism and communication courses, this format is useful because it separates conceptual claims from empirical evidence. Students can revise the theory, replace the fictional data with their own survey or content-analysis data, and render the same Quarto source to HTML, PDF, or Word.

References

1. McCombs, M. E. & Shaw, D. L. The agenda-setting function of mass media. *Public Opinion Quarterly* **36**, 176–187 (1972).

2. Entman, R. M. Framing: Toward clarification of a fractured paradigm. *Journal of Communication* **43**, 51–58 (1993).
3. Iyengar, S. *Is Anyone Responsible? How Television Frames Political Issues.* (University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 1991).
4. Scheufele, D. A. Framing as a theory of media effects. *Journal of Communication* **49**, 103–122 (1999).